

Raccoons: From Pest To Pet [B2]

Cani e gatti dovranno condividere le loro cucce con i procioni? È presto per dirlo, ma c'è la possibilità che gli orsetti lavatori diventino presto animali da compagnia.

They have been [rummaging](#) through our [trash cans](#) for some time now, but soon we may be inviting them into our homes, feeding them, and treating them like family. A recent study published in the journal *Frontiers in Zoology* shows that [raccoons](#) are [undergoing](#) some physiological and [behavioural](#) changes that eventually may lead to them becoming our pets.

TRASH PANDAS

Also affectionately known as 'trash pandas', [raccoons](#) are highly intelligent, medium-sized [mammals](#) with a black bandit mask around their eyes and [bushy, ringed tails](#). With extremely [dexterous paws](#) that they use to open [jars](#), doors, and [latches](#), [raccoons](#) have become experts over the years at finding food in urban environments. They are also very smart; researchers have found that [raccoons](#) can solve [tricky puzzles](#) and remember the answers for years. Two [raccoons](#) in a trash bin.

LEFTOVER LOVERS

The study carried out at the University of Arkansas at Little Rock analysed nearly twenty thousand photos of [raccoons](#) from across the continental United States and found a clear reduction in [snout](#) length in urban [raccoons](#) compared to their rural [relatives](#). According to zoologists, shorter, stronger [snouts](#) are better [suited](#) for [foraging](#) within human habitats, searching through [trash cans](#), breaking open packages and [crunching leftovers](#). Raccoons have also changed their behaviour in order to better navigate and [thrive](#) in human environments. Individuals that are calmer and less [fearful](#) of people are better at getting to [trash cans](#) and other easy sources of food than aggressive ones, since they represent [less of a threat](#)

to humans. Consequently, they have dampened their innate flight response.
Culture

Pet Care: Fireworks And Our Furry Friends I fuochi d'artificio piacciono a tutti, ma non ai nostri amici a quattro zampe. La veterinaria ci consiglia come affrontare le feste più rumorose. Sarah Davison, Melita Cameron-Wood

DOMESTICATION SYNDROME

The reduced snout and the friendlier demeanour belong to a suite of physical and behavioural traits present in domesticated mammals that differ from their wild ancestors, and that Charles Darwin identified as “domestication syndrome”. This set of features — which also includes floppy ears, coat colour changes, and smaller brains and teeth — tends to emerge as animals become more gentle, tolerant, and less aggressive toward humans, and would be part of a wild animal’s transition to tameness and eventually domestication.

LONDON FOXES

These morphological and behavioural processes have also been observed in the UK among foxes. Researchers at the University of Glasgow analysed a collection of about 1,500 fox skulls, comparing those belonging to individuals from London to those from the surrounding countryside. They found that, in addition to shorter snouts, urban foxes had a smaller brain capacity, the reason being that they do not need the mental agility required to catch live prey.

HOW DO YOU SAY...?

Furbo come una volpe. Sly as a fox.

A NEW RELATIONSHIP

In this light, the set of traits described by Darwin challenges the popular concept of domestication as a human-driven process of artificial selection. Rather, foxes and raccoons may be inflicting these changes on themselves to better adapt to an inescapable life around humans, perhaps as dogs and cats did thousands of years before them. Domestication could then start without direct human involvement. In the case of raccoons, the abundance of trash may be the decisive factor that someday leads to a new, closer relationship between these omnivorous and nocturnal mammals and us. The urban fox is more commonly seen in UK and European cities; here one passes 10 Downing Street in London in broad daylight.

GLOBAL EXPANSION

Although native to North America, these adaptable 'backyard bandits', as they are also known, have successfully expanded into urban areas worldwide, from Germany to Japan. Now, the evolutionary selection pressure exerted by human expansion and the destruction of wild habitats may be turning them from pests into pets.

Glossary

- **mammals** = mammiferi
- **dampened** = ridurre
- **traits** = tratti
- **coat** = pelliccia
- **trash cans** = bidoni della spazzatura
- **undergoing** = attraversare
- **tricky puzzles** = enigmi complicati
- **demeanour** = comportamento
- **ringed tails** = code ad anelli
- **jars** = barattoli
- **tameness** = mansuetudine
- **In this light** = visto così
- **bushy** = folte
- **pests** = piaga
- **rummaging** = frugare
- **foraging** = cercare cibo
- **crunching** = sgranocchiare
- **leftovers** = avanzi
- **flight** = fuga
- **human-driven** = indotto dagli esseri umani
- **raccoons** = procioni
- **fearful** = timorosi
- **suite** = insieme, serie
- **skulls** = crani
- **paws** = zampe
- **latches** = chiavistelli
- **snout** = muso
- **relatives** = parenti
- **better suited** = più adatti
- **floppy ears** = orecchie cadenti
- **behavioural** = comportamentali
- **dexterous** = abili
- **thrive** = prosperare

- **less of a threat** = una minaccia minore
- **live prey** = prede vive